

FURTHER ASPECTS OF POLARITY; SELFISHNESS

Greetings, my dearest friends. As always, blessings stream forth. A blessing is a current which is a power to be received by you to the extent you open yourself up to it, knowingly and willingly.

I would like to begin this lecture by discussing the fact that almost always man's unhappiness is supposed to be an indication of sickness. This is usually meant and interpreted in a wrong, distorted way. The result is that man fights the manifestation of his inner being as though the manifestation itself were the sickness. It is of course quite true that if man were entirely in harmony with the universal forces, he would not be sick, neurotic, unhappy. But it is equally true to state that his sickness, his discontent, and his disharmony are an indication of health. For it is precisely man's real self, man's spirit being, which speaks through the unhappiness, sending the conscious ego a message that something should be different. The real self says to the outer personality that it conducts something in a wrong manner. This message comes from health and wants to reestablish health, well-being, and happiness. Truth and life equates with feeling good in the deepest possible way without reservations, in joyful security and self-liking. When man acts and moves in life in a way that is conducive to such a state, the spirit being of his innermost core is completely content. Thus a neurosis, an unhappiness is in a deeper sense a sign of health. The freer man's divine being, the less encrusted and hidden it is, the clearer the outer personality registers its messages. Sometimes this is experienced as "having a conscience." Less developed individuals, whose real self is deeply buried, register such signs much less acutely. They may go along for extended periods of time -- even incarnations -- without feeling their inner discontent, without registering qualms, anxiety, doubt, or pain about their outer deviations from the lawfulness of universal life. They do not register unhappiness when they violate their integrity and may even feel a temporary, precarious sort of satisfaction when they feed the needs of their destructive demands.

Usually it is totally overlooked, or even ignored, that neurosis is, in itself, a sign of a healthy spirit which rebels against the mismanagement of the outer personality. Thus the weight is subtly shifted in regard to what is healthy and what is sick so that the individual combats the very language of the healthy spirit. He then tries to adjust himself to an unhealthy condition in the assumption that his rebellion against this condition is immature, unrealistic, and neurotic.

Now, I do not say that it is not also frequently the case that persons with immature, unrealistic tendencies strive away from self-responsibility, deny any sort of frustration, want to get by with giving nothing and receiving all. You certainly know that these attitudes are decisive factors of the human personality and have to be faced and changed. But the strange thing is that the more man ignores his birthright to be happy and overlooks the messages of his spirit that want to set him into the direction of living according to these basic rights, the more he wants to cheat and get by with giving nothing. In fact, it is a logical connection. The more a human being believes he must

sacrifice his fundamental happiness because to do this is "right," "good," or "mature," the more he becomes deprived, with the inevitable further result of secret destructiveness, ruthless selfishness somewhere underground, as far as emotional inclinations are concerned. These underground tendencies may erupt at any moment. The greater the suppression becomes, the greater the contrasts with the false superimpositions are, the greater will be the likelihood of a breakdown, of a violent eruption which the personality cannot control. We shall come back to this topic later in the lecture.

Let us now take the example of a human being who neglects his personal growth. Inevitably, discontent must exist. But the conscious mind may be unable to read the message of discontent correctly. The diagnosis is made according to the person's understanding of these matters. Only too often professional help consists in trying to make a patient accept his condition in the belief that his frantic struggle is, say, exclusively a rebellion against authority or a self-destructive maneuver against a secure, safe life. The personality's own resistance against recognizing the real cause cooperates, of course, in leading the helper astray. Fear of the consequences of total commitment to growth make it appear more desirable to be merely a recalcitrant child. All this is even more misleading because, as mentioned before, such immature rebellion and self-destructiveness actually exist as well. But they are hardly ever the cause of the evil, merely one of the effects.

You can see how easy it is to be confused about the subtleties of health or neurosis. Neurosis is simultaneously a sign of health and of sickness -- a message leading man toward again feeling good in himself after having lost his proper course. This is, once again, a demonstration of transcendence of duality. The dualistic conception is either sickness or health. Neurosis is thus always seen exclusively as sickness. True as this is, though, it is equally true that it is coming from and striving toward health. It is extremely important, my friends, to approach yourself and your state of mind and emotions in this manner and with this view.

This brings me again to the topic of duality. I repeat, man's tensions and confusions as well as his suffering and his fears are a result of the dualistic state of consciousness in which everything is split in half, in which one half is adjudged as good and desirable, the other as bad and undesirable. This is always an erroneous, illusory way of perceiving and experiencing life. The opposites are not to be divided in this fashion, as I have shown you with many, many aspects in many different lectures. I have attempted to do so again just now. When man, through his personal evolution, transcends the opposites and conciliates them, then and then only can he reach the unitive state. As I also pointed out repeatedly, in order to approach this state, the opposites must be faced and accepted as long as they appear as opposites so that the inner tension diminishes.

There exist some opposites that are no longer experienced as one versus the other, even in this dualistic sphere of consciousness. Mankind has sufficiently evolved to have transcended some of the polarities. In these cases, the average human being no longer experiences one opposite as good, the other as bad. When I say "no longer," I mean that previous states of consciousness existed when this was the case -- with all individuals and in all respects.

Let us take, for example, the masculine and feminine principles I discussed in the last lecture. Only he who is very distorted, very subjectively influenced and disturbed -- and even then it is hardly ever an overt manifestation -- will experience one as positive and the other as negative. The deep psyche, in which not all old obstructions are overcome, still harbors the division of good versus bad.

But generally and to a much larger degree, the average person experiences these opposites in a truthful fashion, that both are intrinsically good and beautiful. They complement one another in a most wonderful way, making one unity, one whole; both contain aspects of the creative universe.

Let us take a further example of where, in a halfway healthy mind, opposites are transcended, are no longer good versus bad, but are seen as complementary facets, both fulfilling their own function, equal in beauty. These are the forces of activity and passivity; the expanding and restricting principles; initiating and receptivity -- to quote the most recent issues under discussion. There are many, many more which are seen as complementary and mutually fulfilling rather than mutually exclusive, even in this overall still dualistic state. Everyone will consider night and day as mutually complementary manifestations of nature, both having their value, their beauty, their functions, and their good reasons. Only the most distorted personality will consider one as good and battle against the other as evil.

These are good demonstrations to perhaps make you sense that in reality it is this way with all opposites, even those that seem most difficult to comprehend in this way. I have attempted to show you that even a pair of opposites like health and sickness is not, in reality, good versus bad. Both can be both. That is, if health prevails while a person violates his spiritual needs for growth, for total feelings of love, for the deepest experiences of happiness, pleasure, union with others, if health continues while an ego remains isolated, separated, and unfeeling for its own innermost self and other people, it is not good. Conversely, ill health is good if seen as a symptom, leading to total health, fulfillment, and happiness.

Thus what is good and what is bad is not ever divisible so that one polarity is one, the other the other. Each polarity is all good when in its natural, undistorted state. Each polarity is bad when distortion and error set in.

This is most difficult to experience with the greatest polarity of all: life and death. Perhaps the foregoing can help a little to wonder, to begin to vaguely sense in a new way, that it can hardly be different with this duality. I must tell you, my friends, that the more you succeed to conciliate polarities within your own soul system and with your soul current, about all sorts of aspects, the more you will sense that it is no different with life and death, that both are good, that none need be feared or fought against. The more other polarities or dualities begin to unify and are experienced as vital functions of living, both being meaningful and beautiful in their own way, the more this is bound to happen regarding life and death.

There are many other opposites that man cannot help but experience, at this stage of his development, as good versus bad. To the degree he has evolved, has come into his own, has realized his divine nature, to that degree he ceases to experience life in this divided way. Only then can the soul be peaceful, only then can soul movements be relaxed and consequently be in a state of delight. For tension breeds unpleasure, makes bliss impossible. And tension is inevitable as long as one is under the illusion that there are always new things to fight against. Soul currents close up toward all good of life when an entity believes itself in danger. Since all opposites are constantly "around," always "there" deep within man's own self as well as around him, he lives in a perpetual state of tension when he assumes one opposite to be good.

Since all of life consists of polarities, the fact that most of them appear as mutually exclusive opposites (one being good, the other being bad, one being grasped at, the other being tensely denied) puts man in a constant state of painful tension, anxious grasping, needless denial. The consequences are pain and frustration. This is all the more confusing when man believes he has done right to fight against the bad and grasp for the good. Why then is he so discontent, so empty, so lacking in the vital joys of life? Such confusions are rarely conscious and concise. If they were, it would be much easier to question and challenge the premises that led to the distortions in the first place. The difficulties are truly illusory, as illusory as the split of good versus bad, but they seem nevertheless real in all the discomfort they give. The opposites he struggles with and against create a tremendous tension in man. He has been geared for centuries and centuries of his psychic existence to feel one opposite as good and right, the other as bad and evil. Thus he inevitably gets lost in confusion. He tries to resolve all his personal problems on this basis and, of course, can never succeed, can never find a real solution that gives him peace. He approaches all his personal alternatives of action in this fashion. Thus the very premise he starts from is already the groundwork for further and deeper entanglement and error.

At times, this tension leads to eruptions, as stated before. At other times, the two polarities, which arbitrarily seem to be mutually exclusive, annul one another. In the groping for a solution with such erroneous premises, always one polarity is set off against the other. Thus they cancel each other out. In the truthful perception, both opposites are accepted and function organically, mutually aiding each other. In the illusory perception of mutual exclusiveness, when they are equally distributed and at the same time fought against, they create a short circuit. In the darkness of the confusion, the individual is called upon to make a choice, but cannot do so successfully. When the distribution is uneven in a nonorganic, distorted way, eruption may occur. When the distribution is even, balanced, again in a nonorganic, distorted way, all power currents become inactivated, short-circuited. What the mind holds true actually happens. The two opposites annul each other. The further result of this state is the numbness, the lifelessness, the deadness of feelings that we so repeatedly discuss in our work together. We often discuss this numbness and deadness in connection with other aspects, which are quite true as far as they go, for example, fear of feelings. But is such a fear not based on precisely such a dualistic struggle, the struggle against choice of polar forces in the inner life of man?

Let us take a simple example that is, at the same time, descriptive of the basic yes- and no-currents (which we also discussed before in different connections). The yes-current represents the affirmative principle, the principle that expands, embraces, is open and receptive to life. The no-current represents the negating principle. It pulls back, it retracts, denies, shrinks into itself. It is an overall conviction and assumption that the affirmative principle is good and desirable, while the negating principle is sick, bad, undesirable. Religion itself has made this division, implicitly representing God as the affirmative, the Devil as the negating power. This is, at best, only a half-truth. To blindly accept this division in the depths of one's unconscious reflexes means untold confusion and pain. The moment a person is governed by such an attitude, he must become involved in errors leading to further errors and misinterpretation of life until it becomes increasingly more difficult to extricate himself from the maze.

I will demonstrate this in the simplest possible way. To affirm an undesirable condition, a destructive attitude, is as undesirable as it is to negate a positive, constructive condition or attitude. Hence, to an individual geared to only affirm, any negation would be experienced with pangs of

hesitation, doubt, uncertainty, and guilt even if negation is healthy and constructive in a particular situation. (I discuss, of course, very subtle levels of reactions which are lodged in the unconscious or semiconscious mind.) The next link in this chain reaction is difficulty to assert oneself, difficulty to take one's inherent rights as a part of creation, difficulty to be healthily aggressive. Such an individual feels compelled to always submit, to never say no to any demands, no matter how exploitative. The spinelessness and weakness of many people is a result of a deep-seated fear to deny anything. This is not at all real goodness based on the free giving of love, on the generous spirit of wanting to give of oneself. It is a subtle fear to make any self-assertion, to claim anything for the self. Such lack of freedom and selfhood decreases the love capacity and increases underlying separateness, selfishness in the destructive way. So you can see, my friends, even with the apparently obvious good versus bad of the yes- and no-currents, it is never one versus the other. It would be totally mistaken to adopt the affirmative principle as an overall attitude for all contingencies and to negate the negating principle.

I am showing once again that the dualistic world view leads to error and suffering, to confusion and tension, and away from all true solutions. The conciliation of all polarities lies in seeing the good in both opposites. This alone will lead to truth, reality, health, the unfoldment of universal bliss, expansion of consciousness. This has been underlying all my lectures. But as we proceed further and further and as you go deeper within yourself, it becomes more and more important that you gradually reorient all your faculties of living according to the unified principle. This applies first to your thinking processes, later to the most subtle emotional reactions and perceptions. More and more you will come to the point when you can embrace both opposites in their truthful, real, healthy manifestations. More and more will you become attuned to recognize their healthy and their distorted versions. You will feel perhaps more than judge through thinking processes, which are which.

In this same vein, I should like to discuss the very important topic of selfishness. In the course of our work together, we have of course touched on this topic in various ways. But in this lecture, I should like to be a little more explicit and go a little deeper. For it is an extremely important topic that has a great many ramifications in each human existence, in each human psyche, and therefore inevitably also in his outer life. At the same time, the topic is a difficult one because it may so easily mislead childish, self-centered, falsely selfish, separating personalities, who may desire to proclaim their destructive selfishness, their separateness as health and selfish-assertion. This is why I have waited a considerable time before going into detail on this topic. Most of my friends have sufficiently progressed in their capacity to distinguish between healthy and destructive selfishness so that they will not fall into the danger of pretending one be the other. This danger must be avoided. Then the comprehension of these words will represent a great liberation for you.

It is an overall and universally accepted concept of mankind to adjudge selfishness as wrong, bad, undesirable, while all kinds of unselfishness are deemed to be laudable, good, right. One rarely makes the discrimination that forms of selfishness exist that are intrinsically healthy and right that guard a person's inalienable right to be happy, that protect his ability to grow, expand, evolve. Concomitantly, one rarely sees that unselfishness can be a sick manifestation of self-destructiveness, weakness, exploiting others through self-enslavement just as one allows others to exploit him. This has little to do with genuine concern for the rights of others. In fact, only he who can be selfish in the right, healthy way is capable of genuine concern for the rights of others.

Selfishness has a tremendously healthy origin. Its origin says: "I am a manifestation of God. As such, I am, in my healthy unobstructed state, a happy individual. For only a happy individual can spread and give forth happiness. Only an individual who grows according to his potentials and his ingrained destiny is happy. Thus happiness and the fulfillment of one's destiny are synonymous. The one is unthinkable without the other. I am also a totally free individual, autonomous and completely responsible for the life I shape for myself. No one else can determine my life, my growth, my happiness. I will not allow myself to subtly hitch this responsibility onto others by 'buying them' through my false unselfishness, through enslavement, through making myself feel so unselfish because I abdicate my rights."

The above realization cannot be deeply enough assimilated. Meditate over this in the most personal and deepest way and see in what way you inadvertently deviate from such an attitude. The more you come to express this honest, healthy, and self-responsible way of life, the more you will feel secure in yourself because security is found by being anchored within yourself. Thus truth brings out the divine kernel, which itself becomes your anchor. False unselfishness makes man lose this center. He is then anchored in the other person for whom he sacrifices. Whenever such attitudes are truly faced, it shows that never, never can such a sacrifice be made in genuine, spontaneous love, in a free spirit of spontaneous giving. For when such is the case, the very idea of sacrifice is no longer applicable. The act is so pleasurable that it is as selfish as it is unselfish. Unselfishness is selfishness, and vice versa. Sacrificial unselfishness always connotes an inner bargaining, a secret desire to get away with something, while there is an outer sentimentality that pretends the act to be good. It is always, always loveless and defeats growth.

When man is anchored not in his own real self but in the approval of others through which he hopes to gain his selfhood, his self-respect, and his happiness, he cannot comprehend the messages of his divine nature. He is disconnected from his vital life center. He founders in contradictory alternatives, gets confused about what is right or not, for him as well as for those he is involved with.

As a result of his decentralization of this being, he pursues a path in which unhappiness is equated with unselfishness, which is equated with being a good person. This error is only the beginning of a cycle of further errors, creating many chain reactions of destructive emotions and attitudes -- to name only a few: self-deception about what is being good; dependency (which is also interpreted to mean love for and concern with the person one is dependent on); weakness, helplessness, false humility -- therefore rage, anger, rebellion. The more these must be kept underground so as not to disrupt the false structure, the greater the discrepancy between the surface and the underlying emotions. The greater the outer, assumed, sacrificial unselfishness becomes, the more the ensuing rage and hostility will build up destructive selfishness under cover. In the emotions and hidden desires, one pays no heed at all to the other fellow whom one would gladly elbow out of all his rights since the other fellow cannot have a reality for him who gives himself no reality. The hidden, destructive selfishness is fear and makes guilt an obstruction that seems insurmountable just because the picture underneath is so different from the one on top. He who cannot be selfish in the right and healthy way does not experience himself in reality. It is all a game, how to get by most easily with a minimum of investment into life. How can anyone who does not take himself, his growth, and his happiness sufficiently seriously and as real factors to be reckoned with, experience other people as sufficiently real to have concern for their true being?

When selfishness is deemed to be bad, and unselfishness to be good, regardless of the how and the why, duality and error are rampant. Therefore conflict between self-interest and the interest of others is inevitable. It seems indeed a real conflict. And on that level, it is. But once the duality is transcended, such conflicts no longer exist. For what is good for one's own real self must absolutely and inevitably also be good for the real self, real ultimate happiness and growth of the other person. In the realm of inner reality, of universal truth to be found in the depth, there can never be a conflict between the real interests of individuals. Conflicting interests exist only on the superimposed levels of falseness, of neurotic needs, of destructively selfish and exploitative demands that hinder the unfoldment of truth and the happiness of all concerned.

When the duality splits selfishness into false divisions and false values so that untruthful, pretended, and distorted attitudes prevail, that which destroys true growth and happiness is deemed the right thing. It lends false humility, thus false pride, to him who sacrifices. It makes an exploiter out of him who accepts the sacrifice -- always under the guise of righteousness. Can this be furthering truth and beauty, bliss and unfoldment? -- for either him who sacrifices or him who blindly accepts it? Even if it can be claimed outwardly that such an arrangement connotes the righteous action, is this truly so? What takes place in the psyches of both people involved in such an interaction? He who accepts must have a growing guilt. Yet, he cannot permit himself to face it, for this would make the structure he built collapse -- and he does not want to part from such a situation. I already mentioned the rebellion, anger, and false sense of goodness, the spirit of being victimized that takes hold of the psyche of the self-sacrificing person.

When the polarity of selfishness/unselfishness is reconciled, the self is accepted as the center of existence, not by evaluating oneself as more important than the other fellow, but by knowing your ego is responsible for your life. It is the carrier in this life, the captain who determines which way to go. Only then is it possible to perceive and experience that you and the other are one within. You will inevitably experience that self-interest in the right way can never, never interfere with the interests of the other where it really counts, on the deepest level. However, even self-interest in the right and healthy way almost always interferes with the egotistical self-interests of the other fellow. This is why following one's true self-interests is often a great struggle and requires a lot of courage. The world around man fights it and deludes itself into claiming what is true self-interest is nothing but egotism and destructive selfishness. This is why it needs a strong person to withstand the disapproval of the world to follow his own spiritual path. And since one's own spiritual path cannot be anything but blissful and since the world is geared to believe that that which is blissful is wrong and selfish, how strong and independent man must become in order not to be influenced and feel falsely guilty for that which truly deserves no guilt. Yet, man must overcome a number of these deep obstructions and resistances before he can come to feel that the path of growth itself is the most blissful experience imaginable. All self-deceptions must be eliminated before this truth can unfold itself to man.

If you understand this principle, my friends, and proceed from here on, and ask yourself a number of questions, what will happen to you will be a wonderful new awakening. Perhaps you will begin in this phase of your path work to ask, "What makes me most happy?" If you go very deep, you must see that what makes you really happy must be constructive, growth bringing, must make you more connected with cosmic life, hence with God. You must see also, if you go deep enough and do not stop in hesitation and fear of your probing, that it cannot be against the true interests of growth and unfoldment of those whose egotistical, sick interests play into your own fearful,

dependent self, that wants to abdicate self-responsibility. Healthy self-interest can be against the interest of stagnation and nongrowth of yourself and others. Once you view this frankly and unsentimentally, the courage to be yourself will arise in you from such truthful vision. All falsity, and with that, much suffering and tension will fall off. The kernel that is so simple will remain: what produces growth, unfoldment of the soul must also produce vital happiness, vibrant stimulation and pleasure. For such is the goodness of God's world. It is the distortion of God's world that makes that commendable which does not further the evolution of the individual.

Be blessed, all of you, my friends, be deeply in the truth of your divine being. Let yourself become more and more what you truly are, God.

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